

TAMBARAM

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An initiative to recycle clay Ganeshas started by Teynampet resident Malini Kalyanam has impacted many resident groups in Chennai and beyond. Under the aegis of The PALM, headquartered in Tiruvallur, the 'Beautiful Bharat — Save Clay' drive has found volunteer groups across Tamil Nadu

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

At SSM Nagar in Alapakam, New Perungalathur, residents have been having an extended Ganesh Chaturthi for the last three years, making the clay Ganeshas central to a recycling initiative. As in the previous two years, under an in-house initiative, 'KAATRU' (Keeping Awareness And Action Towards Recycling and Upcycling), helmed by P.S. Jayaraman, has collected clay Ganeshas and kept them ready for potters.

Residents are asked to choose natural, unpainted clay idols and, after the celebrations, leave them at a designated collection point near the Pillayar Kovil. From there, the idols are handed over to potters.

P.S. Jayaraman, a resident of SSM Nagar, initiated this exercise three years ago inspired by a newspaper article about how Malini Kalyanam, pottery artist and environmentalist. "She was in Teynampet. There was a newspaper article saying that Ganesha idols need not be put into water and cause pollution, and that they could instead be given back to potters," he says. The article prompt-

ed Jayaraman to contact Malini, after which the community arranged for its idols to be collected and sent to potters.

The arrangement changed in the second year, when Jayaraman began looking for potters who could directly collect them from the community. "I looked on Google and contacted four or five potters inside Chennai," he says. Eventually, a potter near Kovalam connected him with another potter in Mahabalipuram, who agreed to collect the idols and reuse the material. "From the second year onwards, we started sending the idols directly to him. Last time, we sent around 900 to 1,000 Ganesh-

as," Jayaraman says.

This year, around 200 to 250 idols had already been collected, with residents expected to continue bringing them in until the afternoon of September 19. Jayaraman has also been urging residents to think about their choices before the festival. The campaign asks them to avoid Plaster of Paris idols, non-eco-friendly paints and decorations. "I have been talking only about clay. I have been telling them not to buy painted Ganeshas or plaster Ganeshas," he says.

For Malini Kalyanam, who is Director of the Artistic Pottery Training Academy in Kattupakkam and

one of the founders of The PALM, a public charitable trust, the issue goes beyond what happens to an idol after the festival. As a pottery artist, she has also watched the availability of natural clay decline. This year, her academy received enquiries from corporates as well as members of the public looking to purchase clay for Chaturthi workshops, only to find it difficult to source.

"This year we had enquiries from corporates and the public alike to purchase clay for Chaturthi workshops, and that is when they said it is not available online or even at shops in the locality. This shows that demand is high

Clay Ganeshas collected at SSM Nagar. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

but supply is on the lower side," she says. Malini says the recycling project has been around for nearly a decade, but awareness has picked up considerably in recent years. With more people asking what they should do with their idols after the festival, the initiative has gradually expanded into a larger conversation about responsible celebration.

Malini, a Teynampet resident who has shifted her base to Tiruvallur for running The PALM, notes that the clay Ganesha idols recycling initiative, titled "Beautiful Bharath — Save Clay" powered by The PALM, has grown bigger, being pan-Tamil Nadu now as volunteers from across the state, which includes P.S. Jayaraman of SSM Nagar, are chipping in. Malini notes plans are afoot to extend the initiative to cities such as Mumbai and Hyderabad.

An extended and green Ganesh Chaturthi

An alternative application

Malini Kalyanam notes that if a collection facility or a potter is not available, the clay from the Ganesha idols can be used in tree-planting exercises. She suggests placing the idol in a bucket of water and letting it break down over a few days. Once the clay settles into a powder, it can be reused. However, Malini says, the clay should not simply be poured around a plant or sapling and expected to act as element of nourishment. For it to support plant growth, it needs to be mixed with other materials. She lists the ingredients that mixed with the clay that has dried up as a powder and found impressive results: garden soil, compost, perlite or sand, mushroom molasses and water. The ratio of the ingredients would depend on the sapling, she notes.



Velachery resident collects Ganesha idols



Lakshmi Prabha, 68, a Velachery resident, came to Chennai in 1989 and began collecting Ganesha idols. Her collection started when she bought her first 12 pieces, finding them reasonably priced. She initially kept the idols as part of her Golu display. One of the first idols that caught her attention was a unique Ganesha wearing a coat. However,

the piece was later banned, and she could not find another one like it. In 1998, her daughter gifted her nine Ganesha idols, most of which she had bought from Archies. Lakshmi Prabha also began collecting idols whenever she visited Puducherry. Over the years, she has collected around 120 terracotta Ganesha idols.

Among her collection

is a paper-holder Ganesha with a crown, which she bought for Rs 40. The response from people who visit her house and see the collection excites her. This year, she began arranging the collection on Friday at 11 am and continued until 9.30 pm.

The idols in her collection are made from a wide variety of materials, including terracotta, clay, gold, silver, wood, white stone, paper mould, porcelain, glass, cement, brass and black stone.

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TAKING A SHOT AT A RARE AVOCATION

Dealers of airguns in Chennai note that enthusiasts of recreational airgun target shooting are on the rise **P4**



CHENNAI'S LITTLE KRISHNAS AND RADHAS

More than 1,000 children participated in this edition of *The Hindu Downtown Maya Kannan* **P2**

‘Barricade the opening along the tracks’

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Residents of East Tambaram have requested Southern Railway to barricade an opening along the tracks at Sudhanandha Bharathi Street.

On GST Road, the iron and steel railings on the median wall that demarcate the railway area has fallen down and the railings have been tied to the adjacent railings. A new railing needs to be fixed or replaced.

S. Gayathri, a resident of East Tambaram East says: “Pedestrians pass through the motor pipes (subway sump room), which drain water from the vehicular subway. They are at risk of being knocked down by electric and express trains. Pedestrians can fall when negotiating over the stones. As there is an overgrowth of bushes, commuters can get bitten by insects and snakes.”



Pedestrians walk along the subway pump room to cross the tracks to reach West Tambaram.





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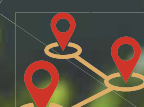
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Chennai’s little Krishnas and Radhas steal the limelight

More than 1,000 children from across Chennai and the neighbouring districts of Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu participated in this edition of *The Hindu Downtown* Maya Kannan

Maya Kannan 2026 authored by *The Hindu Downtown* concluded on a joyous note with the grand prize distribution ceremony held at Gyan Bhawan Auditorium in AM Jain College, Meenambakkam on September 13.

The contest received an overwhelming response with the participation of more than 1,000 children from across Chennai and the neighbouring districts of Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu. As part of the Chennai edition which covers the KTCC districts, the contest was organised across five *Downtown* zones, with 13 winners selected from each zone, taking the total number of winners to 65.

The winners were shortlisted after careful evaluation by the jury, with performance, creativity and overall presentation being key considerations. The presence of several children dressed as little Krishna and Radha added a special charm to the occasion, making the selection process particularly challenging for the jury.

After the winners were finalised, they were invited to the prize distribution ceremony along with their parents and families.

The event became an opportunity not only to recognise the young winners but also to celebrate the encouragement and support provided by their families.

The programme began on a graceful note with captivating classical music and dance performances by the talented students of AM Jain School. Their well-presented performances

added a cultural touch to the celebration and were thoroughly enjoyed and appreciated by everyone present. The guests who participated in the inauguration are: P. Suresh Chand Chordia, management committee member, A.M. Jain Educational Institutions, Gayathri, general manager, A.M. Jain Educational Institutions; Vinod Balaji, managing director, Narpavi; S. Ramalingam; insurance advisor and mutual fund distributor; Balaji, store manager, Poorvika Appliances.

The sponsors: The title partner

for the event was Gopuram Turmeric Powder & Kumkum, co presented by Dheepam Lamp Oil, Poorvika Appliances. Associate Partners for the event were Narpavi, S.Ramalingam, Insurance Advisor and Mutual fund Distributor and T.T. Asafoetida. The food partner was Cafe Coffee House, the venue partner was A.M.Jain College. Meenambakkam, Chennai, and the water partner was Repute Water. Gifts were sponsored by Hिलaptop.com. DIFA, Naga food products, P S Tamarind, RAS Chekku Oil, Vivekanandha Sarees and Priyadarshini Cell Universe.

From the event held at AM Jain College in Meenambakkam on September 13. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Winners of Tambaram zone



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Taking a shot at a rare avocation

Dealers of airguns in Chennai note that enthusiasts of recreational airgun target shooting are on the rise

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

A sharp crack followed by a silence probably lasting just a picosecond and therefore going unregistered, and then the loud pop of a balloon bursting from a pellet shot. Those sounds, in that sequence, are heard every day at Marina and Bessie. And usually, to create that sequence of sounds ten times on the trot, with the hire of an air rifle and a balloon target screen, a beach-goer would have to part with ₹50. There are those who seek to make this one-time indulgence a regular habit not by visiting the beach every day, but by a one-time visit to a shop selling airguns.

Welcome to the hobby of recreational airgun shooting which can be practised in a controlled environment at one's own private space. At Asian Air Guns on Perambur Barracks Road, Ashwin Kumar underlines that owning an airgun does not entail getting a license by meeting a fusillade of requirements. That said, there are still requirements to be met. One, the buyer has to be at least 18 years of age and offer proof of identity by presenting a copy of their Aadhar card or driving license. "Aadhar card is preferred," he emphasises.

Another requirement, something that cannot be met by the presentation of a photocopied document, is responsible behaviour. There is discretion to be followed while carrying an air rifle or air pistol. Brandish it in public, and you would find yourself on the wrong side of the law, the act being counted as a punishable offence. While being transported, the airgun has to be carried in a case, covered and hidden from

the public, Ashwin explains.

"When we sell an airgun, irrespective of the price at which it is sold, we take a primer on how to use it, which includes how to use it responsibly. We cannot expect everyone to know the dos and don'ts of it and hence the time, 30 to 45 minutes, we spend educating them," says Ashwin, adding that airgun literacy is indispensable given that target shooting enthusiasts are on the increase. A good number of them take up target shooting away from the glare of the sporting arena because of the quiet benefits it brings to the mind: focus and stress-busting rejuvenation. But an equally good number of them would be cutting their shooting tooth on airguns with the objective of eventually graduating to professional shooting, which involves get-

ting a license. Ashwin likens it to learning to ride a basic scooter before entering a bike race, "If you want to become a bike racer you first learn to ride an Activa."

Besides the logical learning process, there is also economy involved in taking it step by step. He elaborates: "Joining a shooting club and taking up advanced training would automatically lead someone to invest heavily in costly equipment. And what if someone discovers shooting is not their thing after making that investment? Airguns is a

cost-effective way for someone to find out whether shooting is for them or not." And even with an air pistol and air rifle, one could enter a competitive fray, nationally and internationally, as a category with 10M air rifle for men and women and air pistol for men and women exists.

Ashwin brings this perspective to table as he has been on the other side of the counter as well, as a buyer of shooting equipment for his own use, being a licensed shooter and a member of Chennai Rifle Club. In fact, he shares a passion

for shooting with his father S. Ramesh Balaji who established Asian Air Guns in 2005. Both father and son have made a comeback to the shooting range, the former after a 25-year hiatus and the latter, a 10-year break. But as for their business, they want to stick to selling just airguns.

Anna City Armoury also has a history etched with father-son teamwork. Located on Raja Muthiah Road in Periamet, the shop was started in 1993 by T. Selvamani, who had earlier worked with P. Orr & Sons. The "Armoury" in the enterprise's name signifies continuity in Selvamani's professional life. P. Orr & Sons had a link with the armoury business before being associated entirely with horology. The last embers of its identity as a manufacturer and seller of firearms were smouldering in 1967.

Anna City Armoury is run by Selvamani's son, S. Sivabalan, 49, who joined his father while pursuing his degree, and would go on to take over the business entirely after his father's demise in 2015. The shop deals in airguns as well as firearms that require license on the part of the buyer as well as the dealer. Sivabalan admits that the latter, that is selling airguns is the easier proposition. But that is not without its challenges either: one of them is that helped by technology, manufacturers sell directly to consumers with the result that the middle ground occupied by dealers has narrowed.



Airguns on display; airguns at a balloon popping shop in Marina; T. Selvamani founder of Anna City Armoury at Periamet; and Ashwin Kumar of Asian Air Guns at Perambur Barracks Road.



Niche Trades & Hobbies

This section tracks businesses that deal in rare products and follows groups that need those products to keep their hobbies going



Clear the bushes at Chitlapakkam Lake

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Walkers at Chitlapakkam Lake have requested the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation and the Water Resources Department to clear the bushes growing on the lake bund.

The western bund along Periyar Nagar-Periyar Street in Tambaram Sanatorium (East) - East Tambaram and along the southern bund, near Ramakrishnapuram, East Tambaram, are overrun with these bushes.

S. Chandrasekaran, secretary of The Chitlapakkam Anna Nagar Residents' Welfare Association, says, "As many people walk on the bunds (along the southern bund, a walking path, and western bund, earth soil), they fear snakes." He recommends removing vegetation growing on the walkway itself as it can damage the path.



Chitlapakkam Lake area bund along Periyar Nagar in Tambaram Sanatorium (East).

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Workshop on human values and democratic principles



Sri SaiRam Institute of Management Studies, Sri SaiRam Engineering College recently conducted a workshop on Human Values and Democratic Principles at SSR Hall in College premises. T.S. Krishnamurthy, former Chief Election Commissioner of India, M. Mathivanan IRS, Principal Commissioner of Income Tax, Chennai and Nirmala Lakshman, Director and Publisher - *The Hindu* Group of Publications were the guests of honour.

Medians needed at sharp bends in Guindy



At this bend on Race Course Road, near a car service centre, a median is needed to prevent accidents.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

K. THILAGAVATHY

Greater Chennai Corporation has constructed medians at three areas on Race Course Road in Guindy. While this has helped demarcate the traffic on the road, we also want a similar road divider at two other locations, one near a car service centre and the other at MGR Street in Bharathi Nagar.

Motorists from Five Furlong Road, Chakrapani Street, and Mount Road take a sharp left turn and a right turn near the median.

Recently, two MTC buses collided near the centre. Accidents can happen when motorists from Guindy terminal try to overtake at the bend. Similarly, motorists from Five Furlong Road and Chakrapani Street turn left



along the median area.

Placing medians will curb wrong-side driving.

Likewise at Bharathi Nagar MGR Street, motorists turn sharply right from Furlong Road.

From the terminal to the junction

of Race Course Road, Five Furlong Road, and Chakrapani Street, the Greater Chennai Corporation should install medians to ensure the safety of motorists.

K. Thilagavathy is a resident of Adambakkam

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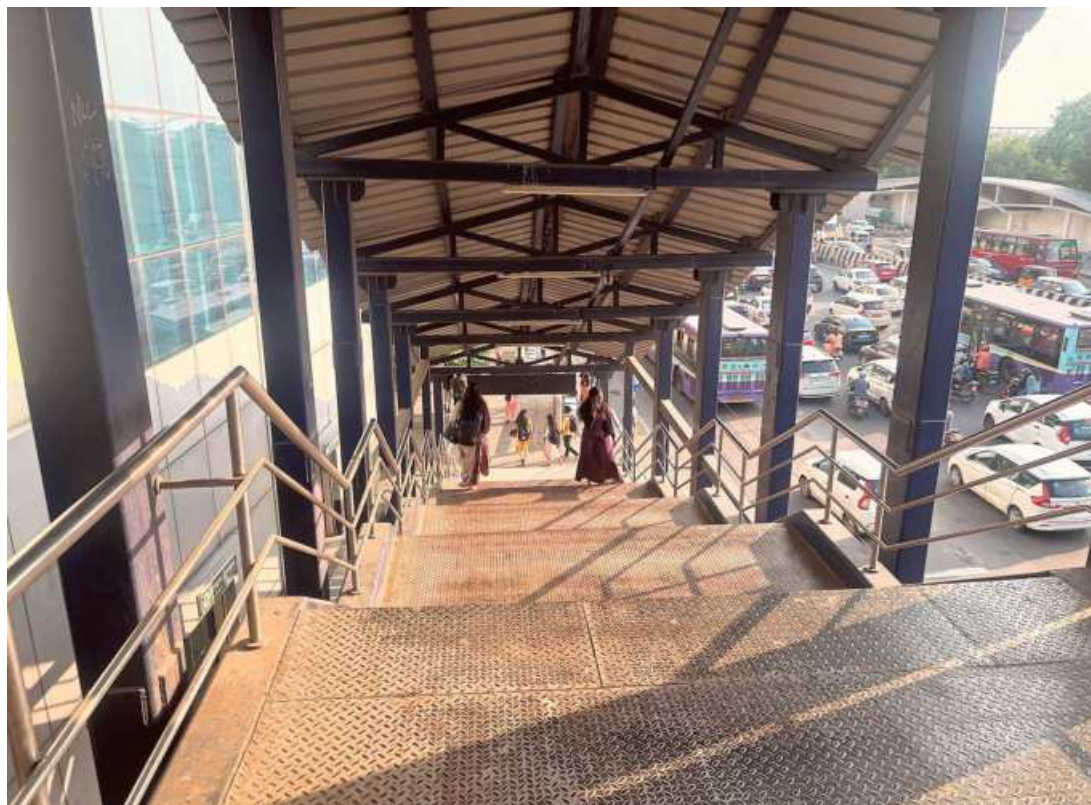
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Not a smooth walk at Alandur FOB

Commuters find the gaps between the steps unusually and dangerously wide

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Pedestrians using Alandur footbridge have asked the State Highways Department to fill the gaps between the steps. The bridge has roughly 70 steps, and the gaps between them are wide causing pedestrians' feet to get trapped.

R. Sharanya Rajendran, a resident of St. Thomas Mount, says when commuters see buses approaching the Alandur metro station halter, they hurry down the steps, and their feet get caught if they are not careful.

S. Keerthana, a pedestrian, says, "The gaps must be closed, or railings must be installed in the

middle.

Pedestrians have to watch their steps, slow down, and not hurry. Further, the iron and steel sheets on the steps and the walkway have begun to rust.

▼ The rusted walkway at Alandur footbridge and the wide gaps in the staircase.

DAC launches luxury residences

DAC Developers, one of the city's leading construction companies, recently launched an ultra-luxury residential apartment project, Balmandaisa, on St. Thomas Mount-Poonamallee Road.

At the launch, the company held a logo-revealing ceremony at its Balmandaisa office.

The residential project offers expansive residences, premium amenities and strategic connectivity. It has 194 residences, of-

fering two-and three-bedroom apartments and four-and five-bedroom duplex residences. The residences are complemented by a standalone ground-plus-three-floor clubhouse spanning 10,000 square feet, said a release.

The project comprises two basement levels, stilt, and 13 residential floors, creating a well-integrated residential community.

The homes are priced from



₹1.19 crore, added the release.

Sathish Kumar Santhanam, founder and managing director, DAC Developers; Kumar Vembu, founder, Mudhal Partners Private Limited and co-founder, Zo-ho; Hari Vignesh R, senior relationship manager, construction finance; Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited, and Manjunath Selvamani, regional sales manager, Prime Home Loans, Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited, took part.

Tambaram residents anxious about monsoon

A one-day hunger strike was organised by Tambaram Makkal Kuzhu to draw attention to a host of issues

More than 100 residents including senior citizens, activists, members of Resident Welfare Associations and representatives of civic and environmental organisations participated in a one-day hunger protest (Adaiyala Unnaviratham) organised by Tambaram Makkal Kuzhu in East Tambaram on September 13, demanding urgent action on a range of civic and environmental concerns affecting residents of Tambaram.

The protest raised concerns over the functioning of the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, particularly its preparedness to deal with flooding and the state of public amenities. Participants also raised concerns over waste management and the proposed reliance on waste incineration as a solution to the city's waste problem.

The protest strongly opposed the proposed public-private partnership (PPP) model for 24x7 drinking water supply in parts of Tambaram.

Residents and members of Residents Welfare Associations argued that drinking water is a public necessity and should remain under transparent and publicly accountable systems rather than being increasingly subjected to private-sector arrangements. This concern comes alongside continuing grievances over water supply and the increase in water charges in Tambaram during 2026.

Waste management

T.K. Shanmugam, president, Federation of North Chennai Residents Welfare Associations, spoke on the growing waste-management crisis and the problems associated with waste incineration.

Representatives of Chitlapakkam Raising, Zone 2 & 3 RWA Federation, Chennai Climate Action Group, Climate Resilience group, Poovulagin Nanbargal, Tambaram Makkal Nala Sangam and various other RWAs and CSOs participated and spoke about the need for sustained public action on civic issues.

Call for action

The programme concluded by Saravanan of Thannatchi and Peoples union of Civil Liberties (PUCL), who emphasised the importance of continuing democratic public action until the concerns raised by residents are addressed.



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